

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*Turning Over Tables:
A Lenten Call for Disrupting Power
Disrupt – Lent 4*

March 30th, 2025



Alma W. Thomas, Launch Pad, 1970

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

*Our Altar and Chancel Arch flowers today are in honor of Judge Bob Ward
and his years of service to First Congregational Church of Los Angeles.*

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Improvisation on NEW DIMENSIONS and LYONS

Cantique de Jean Racine (Gabriel Fauré, adapted for Organ Solo by C. Bull)

Paraphrases of Pie Jesu, Agnus Dei, Libera Me, In Paradisum from *Requiem* (Gabriel Fauré)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Claire Kelly & Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Lulu Gregoropoulos & Gavin Gregorio

So much has been hidden:
To protect narratives and people.
To disempower.
To confuse.

Unsatisfied with stories that get us by
but never get us free,
may we be people who search beyond,
who listen beneath,
who feel through and through.

Though we know only in part,
we do not grow weary in faith.
Though the chaos of injustice shrouds our view,
with each new learning and unlearning
the partial fades away.

The histories
and complicities
and losses
and power
of our entangled lives
cry out for understanding.

With courage, we open ourselves to truth.

With humility, we endeavor to be transformed.

With hope, we hold on to each other.

May Love disrupt and lead us in the Sacred work of unveiling.

May all that shrouds justice be uncovered
and the ways of healing revealed.

[Rev. M Jade Kaiser, enfleshed]

Please stand now in body or in spirit for our Lenten Hymn of Gathering

***Lenten Hymn of Gathering.** *In the Midst of New Dimensions*

NEW DIMENSIONS

In the midst of new dimensions, in the face of changing ways.
Who will lead the pilgrim peoples wandering in their separate ways?
God of rainbow, fiery pillar, leading where the eagles soar,
We your people, ours the journey now and ever, now and ever, now and ever more.

Through the flood of hurting people, warring factions and despair,
Who will lift the olive branches? Who will light the flame of care?
God of rainbow, fiery pillar, leading where the eagles soar,
We your people, ours the journey now and ever, now and ever, now and ever more.

As we stand a world divided by our own self seeking schemes,
Grant that we, your global village, might envision wider dreams.
God of rainbow, fiery pillar, leading where the eagles soar,
We your people, ours the journey now and ever, now and ever, now and ever more.

-Words and Music by Julian Rush [1985-adpt/lvf]

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Michael Lehman

Mysterious and Powerful Love—disrupt and shake our old ways!
Make vivid a new path.
Radicalize our spirits towards compassion.
Alchemize our anger into hope and change.
What joy, what delight to be found in co-creating beauty with you, O God,
and with each other.
What wonder to be found in open-hearted living.

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Amen.

***Introit**

"March Of The Women"
Cathedral Choir

ETHEL SMYTH

***The Lord's Prayer**

Rev. Michael Schiefelbein

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kindom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.*

*And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

As we continue through this Season of Lent, let us hold each other carefully
as we journey...

In caring for one another,
may we be untiring
In challenging one another,
may we be respectful,
In sheltering one another,
may we be strong,
In holding one another,
may we be tender.

In the expectations we have of one another,
may we be realistic.
In the songs we sing together,
may we seek harmony.
And in loving one another,
may we be all these things and more.

As we seek to hold faith together, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Readings from the Wisdom of Our Tradition Rev. Tanaka Pack & Rev. Michael Schiefelbein
from the Gospel of Luke

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer
Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

God who feels,
God who pays attention,
God who formed webs of life entangled,
Help us to notice today...
To notice our bodies – what they are telling us they need.
To notice our neighbors – who they are and how they are.
To notice the creatures and creations around us – each, a valuable life.
You know our limitations, O God of Wisdom,
what is enough or too much to be aware of all at once,
or too much to connect with, to feel, to hold.
May we not rush past what needs or deserves our attention.
Neither may we be overwhelmed by trying to bear more than our share.
Simply help us to be alive to what is,
alive to you, within and around us, every moment.
[m jade kaiser, enfleshed]
May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem. “Mache dich mein Hertze rein” from *St. Matthew Passion*
David Conley, Soloist

J.S. BACH

*“Make yourself ready, my heart. I want to lay Jesus to rest myself.
He shall sweetly dwell within me forever. World, get out, let Jesus in!”*

Sermon

Disrupt

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

“More Waters Rising” SARO LYNCH-THOMASON, arr. SAUNDER CHOI
Cathedral Choir

*Lenten Doxology

Praise God from whom all blessings flow.
Praise God, all creatures here below.
Praise God above ye heavenly hosts.
Creator, Christ, and Holy Ghost. Amen.

*Prayer of Offering

Rev. Michael Schiefelbein

Spirit of Liberation, determined and gracious,
Through these gifts, teach us of loyalty to love's ways.
May we become more committed to each other's flourishing.
May we be released from fears that cause us to hoard resources, power, and control.
May we become convinced of the power you have given us to disrupt, resist, and transform our world through loving intention, commitment, and peace.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

**Life at First Church
Words of Blessing**

**Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman
Rev. Fregin**

May God bless us with disruption
and the courage to face discomfort,
that we may grow in compassion for those who suffer.

*May God bless us with restlessness,
so that we are not content with the injustices of this world.*

May God bless us with humble hearts,
to sense and know the sacred in ourselves and in all.

*May God bless us with deep and unwavering peace,
that it might hold us in the chaos and the quiet alike.*

And may we always remember,
that in the disruption, the discomfort, and the struggle...
God is present, ever guiding us toward love.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Choral Response

"Good Trouble"
Cathedral Choir

THOMAS KEESECKER

***Hymn for the Journey**

O Spirit of Power

LYONS

O Spirit of Power, who dwells in us all,
Inspire us each hour to follow your call.
Awaken our vision to all we can be,
And challenge our labor to set people free.

Though many your names, Love reigns over all;
With you we can claim our life giving call.
Cast out all our fear so with you we can soar,
Creating a world never dreamed of before.

O Spirit of Love, compassionate Friend,
Within and above, your strength knows no end.
Your rivers of healing revive thirsty land;
All goodness and nourishment flow from your hand.

O Spirit of Power, O Love beyond thought,
Our gifts with you flower; what wonders are wrought.
Creator, Redeemer and Comforting Guide,
Illumine our lives as with you we abide.

- lyrics by Jan Aldredge-Clanton

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Fugue in C Major (Adela Douglas-Pennant)

Inside The Music

“Dame Ethel Smyth lived during the early twentieth century, a time when real social change toward equity seemed possible. Her song “March of the Women” galvanized the suffragette movement, and led to women securing the right to vote in England. It is one of a handful of songs in history that we can point to as having a tangible, and outsized, influence on social/political life. She was a leader in many ways. She was unabashed in her queer identity. She was determined as a working composer to have her music performed and published, neither of which was common for women only a century ago. She used her compositional voice to bring focus to society’s inequities. Her music was influential. Sadly, some of the same issues for which she advocated change persist today. Her legacy is a reminder that we all have a voice, and that our voices matter. Equally, we are reminded that disruption doesn’t have to be violent to have meaning and influence lasting change. Saro Lynch-Thomason’s “More Waters Rising” underscores the same message. No matter what we are facing, she tells us through metaphors of water, fire, and mountains, time will bring opportunities for overcoming, and renewal of obstacles. This life will never be a straight line, nor can we ever hope for the values we hold dear to be unchallenged. We must be ready to wade through the water and rebuild the mountains as the world ebbs and flows. “Mache dich mein Hertze rein” is one of the most beautiful arias from Bach’s *St. Matthew Passion*. The *Passion* tells the story of Jesus’ last week of life. “Mache dich” appears near the end of the work, when Jesus is dying. Like many of the arias in that work, it acts as commentary on the story. I like it for this week because in the midst of the intensity of that moment, when their leader and friend approaches death, the song speaks of personal responsibility. It says “I want to be the one to lay Jesus to rest.” In the face of the unimaginable, the baritone sings of taking a step toward the grief, pressure, and challenge of the moment. Disruption can look like overturning tables, yes, and in many ways the decisiveness of such a action feels conclusive. Yet, disruption to unjust systems, even disruption to our own habits that diminish our determination, can be a daily, meaningful ritual life practice.” -Dr. David Harris